

Polenta lasagna

What a culinary shocker—polenta substitutes for pasta noodles in this hearty, enlightened dish. And I find that like traditional lasagna, this dish tastes better the next day, as the **flavors** pull together. As a matter of practicality, I recommend making the polenta the day or morning before preparing the rest of the dish. This will make the whole process much simpler as the polenta will be done and ready, freeing you to concentrate on the sauce and assembling the lasagna.

2 recipes Basic Polenta (page 216)

2 tablespoons olive oil

1 small onion, chopped

3 garlic cloves, minced

½ teaspoon dried oregano

1 bay leaf

⅛ to ¼ teaspoon crushed hot red pepper

1 small red bell pepper, diced

1 small zucchini, halved lengthwise and thinly sliced

1 carrot, peeled and thinly sliced

Salt and freshly ground black pepper

2 cans (28 ounces each) organic crushed tomatoes [875ml or 784g total]

2 tablespoons tomato paste

1 tablespoon balsamic or red wine vinegar

¼ cup plus 2 tablespoons freshly grated Parmesan cheese [40g]

8 ounces mozzarella cheese, thinly sliced [250g]

1. **Prepare** the polenta and pour into a lightly oiled 9 by 13 inch baking dish [23 by 33cm]. Let set until firm, at least 3 hours (or overnight) in the refrigerator.
2. In a large skillet, heat the oil over medium heat. **Add** the onion and cook until soft and translucent, 3 to 5 minutes. Add the garlic, oregano, bay leaf, and hot pepper. Cook for 1 minute longer. Add the bell pepper, zucchini, and carrot and cook another 2 minutes. Season lightly with salt and black pepper. Add the crushed tomatoes and tomato paste and simmer until the vegetables are soft but still slightly firm, 5 to 7 minutes. Remove from the heat. Stir in the vinegar and season with salt and black pepper to taste.

3. Preheat the oven to 350°F [175°C]. **Remove** the polenta to a clean cutting board by sliding a sharp paring knife around the edges to loosen it. Place the cutting board on top of the dish and, firmly holding both together, quickly flip them over. The polenta should pop right out onto cutting board. Depending on the size of the board, you may need someone to help you with this.
4. With a long, thin knife, **cut** the polenta in half vertically, then again in half horizontally. Gently return 2 of the halves to the baking dish.
5. Ladle about 2 cups [500ml] of the tomato sauce over the polenta in the baking dish. Sprinkle on half the Parmesan cheese and layer on half the mozzarella. **Top** with the remaining polenta pieces, another 2 cups [500ml] tomato sauce, and the rest of the cheese. Use any remaining sauce to pour over the finished lasagna.
6. **Bake** for 35 to 40 minutes, or until the cheese is browned on top and a knife inserted in the middle comes out hot.

IMPORTANT! Let the lasagna rest for at least at least 15 to 20 minutes before cutting and serving.

SERVES 8

